

Session 18 read-aloud pack - rebuilt

September 30

Use only the paragraph whose release gate has happened. The pressure witness and bounded dragon motive are approved DM background; discoveries and outcomes remain unplayed. A0 and A1 are alternate openings: choose one. Always say Pat-Benatar in full.

A0 - Story-so-far recap (opening; about two minutes)

At Stormwreck, you stopped Sparkrender's exploitation of the dead, opened the ancient pattern and brought Aidron back alive. You carried Mek home. Runara gave you a direction: follow the dragons if you want to understand the wound. Aidron warned you that finding a dragon would not make it trustworthy.

Greenest put that question into your hands. A dark stone plate, taken from beneath the mill, fits an ancient socket. Its pulse stops at a broken channel. The arch stays shut. Whoever ordered it moved north also wanted what was left behind.

At the Chalk Cut you pulled Doss from fallen stone. At the northern camp you refused payment for the plate and discovered a plan: wagons to draw defenders north, observers to release a signal, a work party to reach the mill. Severed Whisper took the survey map while a dragon passed overhead and continued north. Its identity remains unknown.

You brought Doss home and took the evidence to Greenest's leaders. Now Floyd GoldSeeker and Brother Kai have both work crews at the mill. Pat-Benatar has two guard teams at the ridge. Throk holds the west path with the third. Severed Whisper watches the north road.

The town has listened. The next orders belong to you.

A1 - Opening recap and dusk (before the first action)

You came to the Chalk Cut carrying a piece of an old mystery: a charcoal plate traced with gold, taken from the damaged stonework beneath Greenest's mill. You found a collapsed road, an injured courier, and a transfer that had already missed its deadline. You chose to help. Then you followed the tools north.

At the camp, the tools told a different story from the wagons. Straw sacks, shields and drums were meant to draw eyes toward the north road. Picks and timber braces were meant for the mill. Between them stood two observers with a shuttered lantern, waiting for Greenest to make the wrong move.

You took the papers. Severed Whisper took the map. Above the tents, a dragon passed without a word and continued north. You kept the plate. You brought Doss back to people who could care for an injured leg, and you brought the evidence to Greenest's council.

Now the map has become the ground beneath your feet.

Floyd GoldSeeker and Brother Kai stand at the mill with both work crews. Pat-Benatar has two guard teams near the signal ridge. Throk watches the west path with the third. Severed Whisper has chosen the north road alone.

The last warmth drains from the stone. Somewhere beyond the fields, a drum sounds once. A pause. Then a second drum answers.

Dusk has arrived. What is your first move?

A2 - Wheel arrives (visible convoy only)

The sound reaches you before the wagons do: slow wheels over rutted ground, a wooden rim striking a buried stone, then the heavy beat of a drum. Two wagons come around the bend. Their sacks are piled high enough to be seen from town. Shields hang along their sides.

The wagons stop where the road opens toward Greenest. A figure on the nearer wagon looks past you toward the town, then uphill. The drum keeps beating. Behind it, you can hear the small noises of waiting people: a throat cleared, a boot shifted, a horse blowing through its nose.

They have made themselves visible. They are waiting to see what moves.

A3 - Pat-Benatar reaches the ridge (before confrontation)

The ridge smells of dry grass and cooling stone. Greenest lies below in scattered pools of lamplight. From here, the north road and the low eastern approach are both visible, just as the papers promised.

Two figures shelter behind an outcrop. One watches the town. The other rests a hand on a shuttered lantern. A covered supply light gives their boots and equipment a dim amber edge. Neither has opened the signaling shutter.

Below you, the drums continue. Beside you, the guards wait for Pat-Benatar's order.

A4 - The false light (only after the exact signal is declared)

The shutter moves beneath your hand. Light crosses the dark hillside in the pattern you have chosen, bright enough to be seen by anyone waiting for it.

For a moment the distance gives you nothing back. The road is a strip of gray. The drainage track disappears among shadows. Then someone below stops moving and turns toward the ridge.

Your message has reached them. What they believe it means is about to matter.

A5 - Throk's west-path watch (messenger only if present)

The west path narrows between the orchard and a low bank. Dry leaves scrape over the ground. Behind you, Greenest's lights have begun to show through the branches.

A traveler comes into view on foot, moving quickly until the drums carry across the fields. The traveler stops, looks uphill, and shades a hand over the eyes. There is no wagon, no load of tools - only a small folded packet held close beneath a coat.

The guards glance at Throk. The traveler has not yet reached your position.

A6 - Spade approaches (only if their actual orders cause movement)

Water splashes in the dark outside the mill. A covered tool strikes the wall with a muted iron knock. Through the low opening, you see boots picking their way along the drainage stones, followed by the pale ends of timber braces.

The people approaching carry the equipment you read about: picks, bars, rope. Some look toward the entrance. Others keep watching the ridge behind them.

Inside, your own braces stand against the old stone. The passage is narrow. There is room to speak before there is room to rush.

A7 - After the operation (choose only what is true)

Successful containment: The drums have stopped. The quiet that follows is full of smaller sounds: a runner breathing hard, a cart being brought around, someone asking a companion whether that blood is theirs. Greenest's doors begin to open a little wider. Your orders have held long enough for the town to understand what happened.

Mixed result: The drums have stopped, but the work is not finished. There are people to find, injuries to tend, and one approach that still needs watching. A runner waits with news from another part of town. Your plan has changed the night. Now you must decide what the surviving pieces need from you.

Shared ending: Escobert listens to each report before answering. "Tell me what is secure. Tell me who needs help. Then tell me what we must keep watching while you work."

A7B - The cult dispatch (after actually acquiring H1)

The lower part of the paper is written with fewer abbreviations. The name beneath the orders is Frulam Mondath. Beside it, someone has written Cult of the Dragon.

The mill is a recovery objective. The plate is to go north separately. Another line orders an accounting of prisoners and stock in a guarded cave. These are not the notes of people preparing to settle in Greenest.

You have the shape of the operation. Now you have a name attached to it, and a reason to wonder what else is being moved out of the camp.

A8 - Under the mill (before side access)

The mill's ordinary smells follow you down: flour, river water, damp timber. Beneath them lies the colder smell of stone that has not seen daylight in a long time.

The old arch is where you left it. Its channels run toward the empty rectangular socket and stop at the same damaged branch. Along one narrow seam, a bead of water still climbs upward.

Beside the arch, newer mortar bears the marks of failed tools. The wall carries weight from above. The crews have brought enough timber to change how that weight is held, but every piece must be placed with care.

Floyd GoldSeeker, the safe way in begins with the stone everyone else would simply strike.

A9 - The first opening (after safe clearance succeeds)

The last loosened stone comes away with a soft grind. Cool air slips through the gap and stirs the dust against your hands.

Behind the wall is a small recess, older than the mill above it. There is no room for a great machine. A shaped cradle stands within reach, its edges dark with age. Bronze catches the lantern light where three ribs curve over something long and smoky.

The crews fall quiet. For the first time, you can see what the raiders meant to take.

A10 - The pressure witness (approved DM object; after inspection)

The object is about the length of a forearm: smoky crystal held within three bronze ribs. It rests above the stone rather than against it, supported by small fittings that look made to be released. Inside the crystal, a single amber thread hangs motionless.

The marks along its casing resemble the family of lines you have seen at the Observatory and beneath this mill. They are precise, worn, and too old to have been made for the recent raid.

Three retaining clips are visible. There is room to support the object before you release them.

Near the plate, only if actually tested: When the plate is brought close, a second amber line appears inside the crystal, slightly offset from the first. The two remain apart for a heartbeat. Then the newer line fades. Whatever relationship exists between these pieces, you have seen only its beginning.

A11 - Departure (after choosing to leave and confirming custody)

Dawn version: Morning reaches Greenest quietly. The stone is pale again. Smoke rises from breakfast fires, and the mill's workers step aside as you pass with the burden you chose to carry. Someone has tied fresh padding around it. Someone has counted the food. Behind you, the town returns to the work of staying alive.

Night version: Greenest's lamps follow you to the edge of town. Beyond the last doorway, the road becomes a darker line between fields. The burden you chose to carry is wrapped and secured. Behind you, people are returning to watches, beds and unfinished repairs.

Shared ending: North lies the camp, the transfer route, and the direction taken by the dragon. This time you are not following someone else's delivery schedule. You have chosen to carry both pieces yourselves.

A12 - Northern transfer marker (after earned route evidence)

Three pale stones stand beside the fork, spaced too evenly to be an accident. The deeper wheel ruts continue one way. A narrower track turns toward dark rock above the chalk.

At the end of that track, a split shelf opens over the valley. Wind moves through the gap and carries a dry mineral scent. The ground bears signs of recent passage, but there is no ordinary campfire and no line of waiting carts.

You can see the approach behind you. You can still choose how far to go.

A13 - Dragon threshold (do not imply hidden items are detected)

The shadow beneath the overhang shifts. What seemed to be a ridge of rock separates from the stone behind it. A breath passes through the gap, deep enough to change the sound of the wind.

Two eyes turn toward you.

With both objects disclosed: "Which of you decided to bring both?"

With concealed or uncertain custody: "Tell me what you have come to deliver."

The voice waits. The track remains open behind you. For the first time since you read the transfer order, the next words are yours to choose.

A14 - Earned departure cliffhanger (if the dragon meeting is next session)

Greenest has become a cluster of roofs behind you. The road ahead climbs toward the chalk hills, where your story last followed tools and couriers. Now the things they wanted are traveling north under your protection.

Somewhere ahead, a dragon has been moving for reasons you have not yet heard. You have its possible trail, two pieces of an older mystery, and your own questions.

This time, you mean to ask them face to face.

A15 - The pulse and its price (observe at sanctuary with permission)

Merra rests her fingers beside the pale stone. A patient lets out a breath that sounds as though it has been held for hours. The tightness around their mouth eases.

Below the plinth, a narrow line brightens and fades. From the damaged channel comes a soft fall of grit. The moment of relief and the movement in the stone are close enough that everyone has time to notice both.

Merra looks from the patient to the dust. "It helps," she says. "You can see that it helps."

Eadyan steadies the patient's cup. "Then we need to find a way to keep helping without asking the broken stone to carry more."

They wait for your proposal.

A16 - A limited improvement (only after the chosen intervention works)

Isolation version: With replacement care ready, the receiver is lifted clear. The next expected pulse does not come. No new dust falls from that particular seam. The patient still needs tending. The channel is still broken. But one source of strain has stopped, and someone has written down who will watch the supports while you are gone.

Monitored-use version: The receiver remains under watch. Fresh timber carries the vulnerable load, and the next pulse is observed rather than ignored. Merra checks the patient; Eadyan records the interval; a volunteer checks the brace. The problem remains, but it has people responsible for it now.

Shared ending: You have not healed the whole town with a gesture. You have changed what will happen when you leave.

A17 - The dragon's first bargain (after objects disclosed and conversation begins)

The dragon studies the wrapped burden without moving closer.

"Frulam sends hands to take what she cannot read. You brought it yourselves."

A slow breath stirs the grass against the shelf. The road remains open behind you.

"The bronze dragon on the island was freed. Something old changed its note. That did not break your mill. Your mill was already damaged."

The eyes turn from the smaller bundle to the longer one.

"I can tell you what those pieces compare. You can decide whether I am allowed to examine them. Ask your first question."

A18 - Closing on a chosen next step

The answer you came north for has become something more precise. Old draconic work lies beneath ordinary lives. People can exploit it without understanding it. A dragon can understand part of it and still want something from you.

Behind you are the workers, the patients and the defenses you chose to leave. Before you is an offer, a cult's trail and a damaged place that has not stopped needing care.

This time you have more than a delivery order. You have enough information to choose what comes next.